# 18

TAFT SCHREIBER, WHO HEADED television activities for MCA, knew I was adamant against doing a TV series. But in 1954, he came to me with a proposal: The General Electric Company was in the market for a new television program, and he wanted to propose a weekly dramatic anthology in which I would only act several times a season but serve as the host every week.

I knew that having my face beamed into homes across the country every week risked the kind of overexposure that could be fatal to a movie actor's career. But I liked the idea because it offered me a chance to share in the growing financial prosperity of television while avoiding the kind of typecasting that acting in the same role week after week in a regular series brought with it.

I agreed to do it and thus was born the General Electric Theater, which for eight years at nine o'clock on Sunday nights produced what I think were some of the finest programs to emerge from the period that show business historians now refer to nostalgically as the "Golden Age of Television." Each Sunday, the GE Theater offered a different story with a different cast, and virtually every Oscar winner in Hollywood showed up in one of our plays.

My new job called upon me to play a supporting role in an extraordinary experiment by American industry. Until then, most of America's industrial giants had tended to function under a strong central management within a single geographic region—United States Steel in Pittsburgh and General Motors in Detroit, for instance. But Ralph Cordiner, General Electric's chairman, a remarkable and foresighted businessman, believed GE would grow more dynamically if